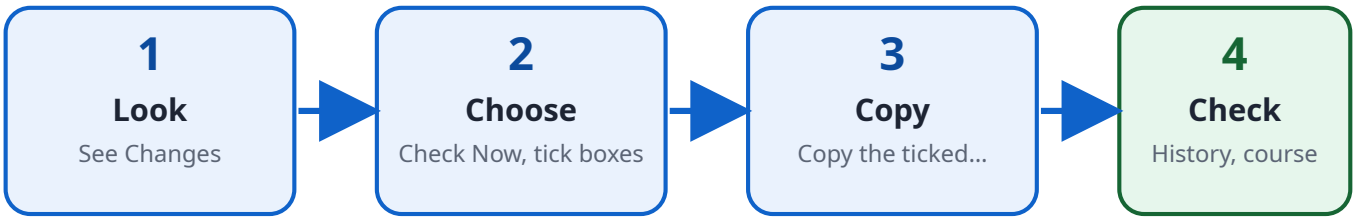
COURSE SYNC FOR MOODLE

Using Course Sync

A step-by-step guide for teachers. Your administrator has already installed and connected the plugin; this guide shows you how to bring activities, grades and student work into your course, one click at a time.



Part 1	What Course Sync does (and never does)
Part 2	Copy activities into your course
Part 3	Keep your course up to date
Part 4	Bring grades, submissions and marks across
Part 5	Sync history, reference and troubleshooting

Written for Course Sync v1.27.0-beta · Moodle 5.0 to 5.3 · Screenshots taken on Moodle 5.1 (Boost theme). If your administrator has not connected your course yet, see the *Set-up Walk-Through* (`SETUP_WALKTHROUGH.pdf`).

PART 1

What Course Sync does

Course Sync brings activities from a course on **another Moodle site** into your course here. You decide when. **Nothing happens on its own.** It runs only when you press a button.

It always

- shows you what it will do *before* it does it;
- lets you untick anything you do not want;
- tells you afterwards exactly what happened.

It never

- changes or deletes something already in your course without your tick;
- overwrites a grade, mark or submission someone gave here;
- copies what students wrote (forum posts, wiki pages, answers).

The buttons you may see

The Course Sync block holds a few buttons. Which ones you see depends on your role and on what your administrator switched on. This is normal: if a button is missing you either do not need it or do not have permission for it.

Button	What it does	You see it when
Check Now	Lists what is on the other course and lets you copy it.	Course is connected
See Changes	Shows what changed on the other course. Copies nothing.	Course is connected
Pull Grades	Brings students' gradebook grades (and quiz attempts) across.	Grade pulling is on, and you can edit grades
Pull Submissions	Brings what students handed in to copied assignments.	Submission pulling is on, and you can grade and edit submissions
Pull Marks and Feedback	Brings assignment marks and written comments.	Marks pulling is on, and you can grade assignments
View sync history	A log of everything that was synced, and when.	Course is connected
Manage the Connections	Change the site, token or course.	Managers only

Does the block say "not yet configured"?
The connection has to be set up first, by a manager or administrator. Ask them to follow the *Set-up Walk-Through*. You do not need to do anything else here.

PART 2

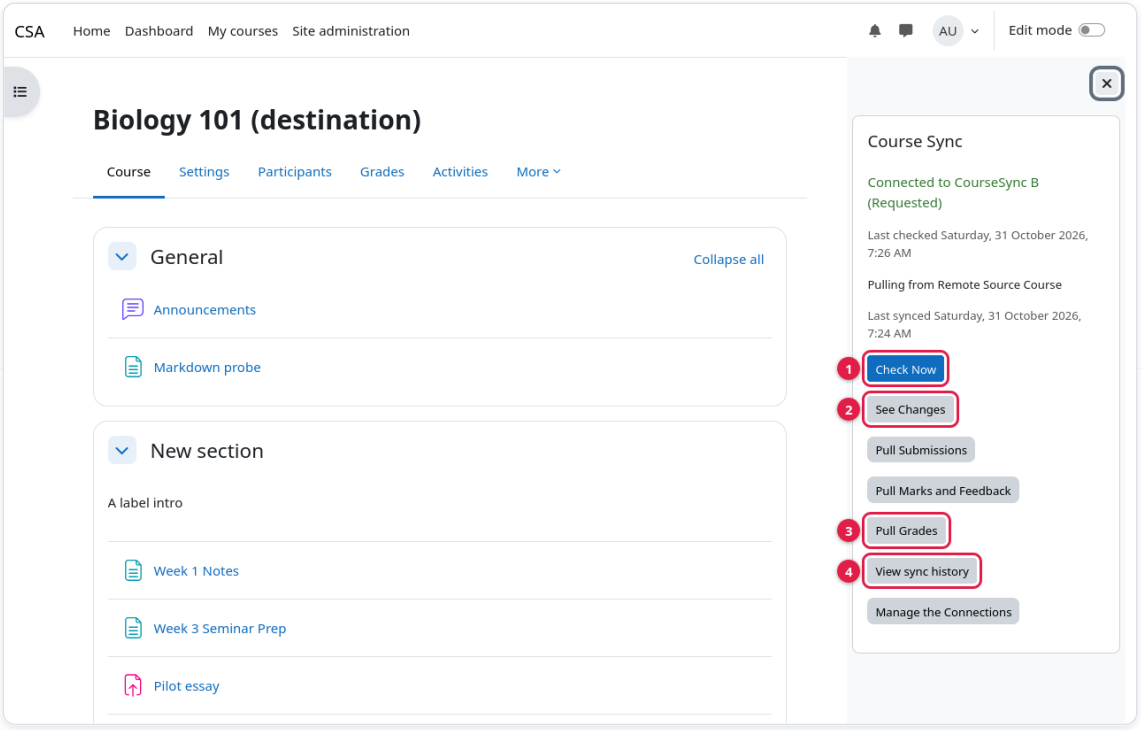
Copy activities into your course

About the screenshots

The pictures come from a test course called “Biology 101 (destination)” that pulls from a course on a second test site. Red numbered circles (1) show where to click, in order. The test course was viewed as an administrator, so you may see fewer buttons.

1 Find the Course Sync block

1. Open your course.
2. The block lives in the **block drawer** on the right. If you do not see it, click the arrow tab on the right-hand edge to open the drawer.
3. Read the status lines. Green **“Connected to …”** means the link works. **“Pulling from …”** names the course on the other site, and **“Last synced …”** tells you when you last copied.

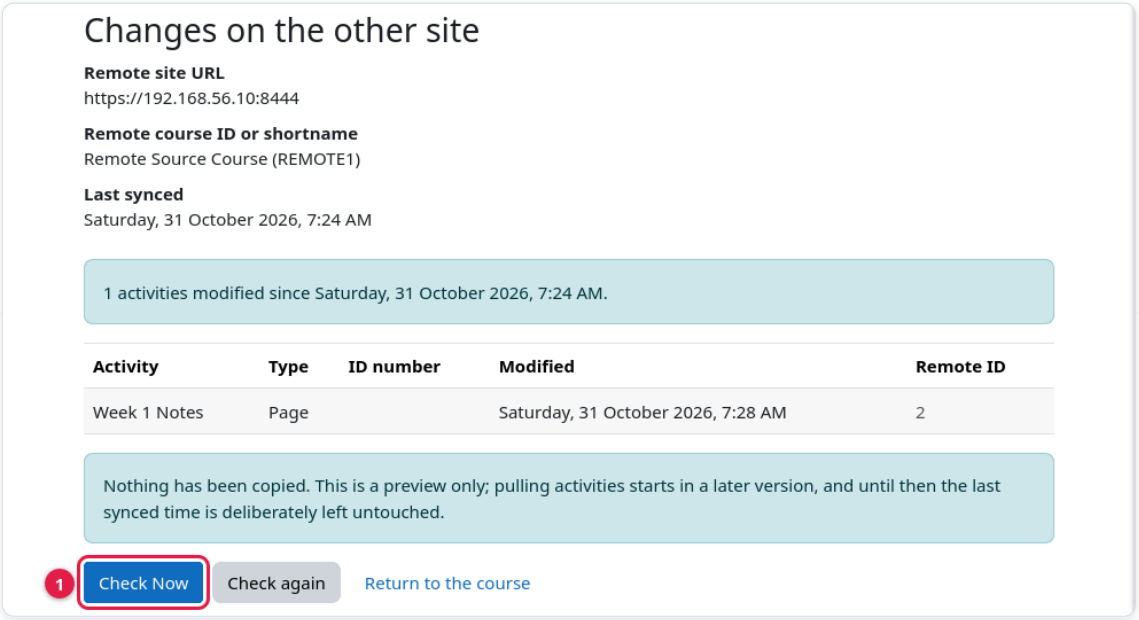


The Course Sync block in the right-hand drawer. (1) Check Now, (2) See Changes, (3) Pull Grades, (4) View sync history. Pull Submissions and Pull Marks and Feedback sit between them when switched on.

2 (Optional) Take a look first with “See Changes”

Click **See Changes** 2 in the block. Course Sync asks the other site what it has and lists it. **Nothing is copied.** It is a safe way to check you are connected to the right course.

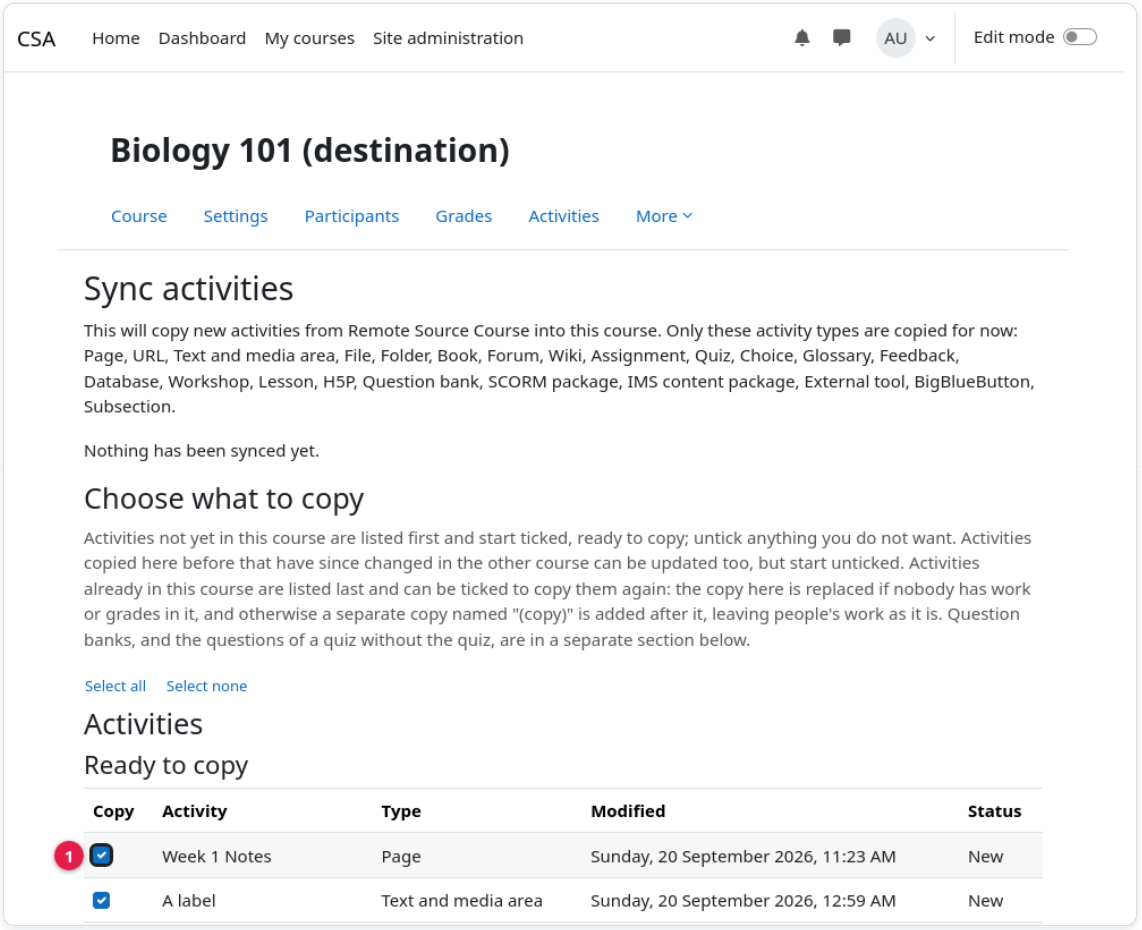
The page reports how many activities changed on the other course since your last sync, with their names. From here you can go straight to **Check Now** 1.



See Changes: one activity, “Week 1 Notes”, has been modified on the other course since the last sync. Nothing has been copied.

3 Click “Check Now”

Click **Check Now** 1 in the block. Course Sync lists every activity in the other course, sorted into groups. The first time, everything is under **Ready to copy**, and each row is **already ticked**.



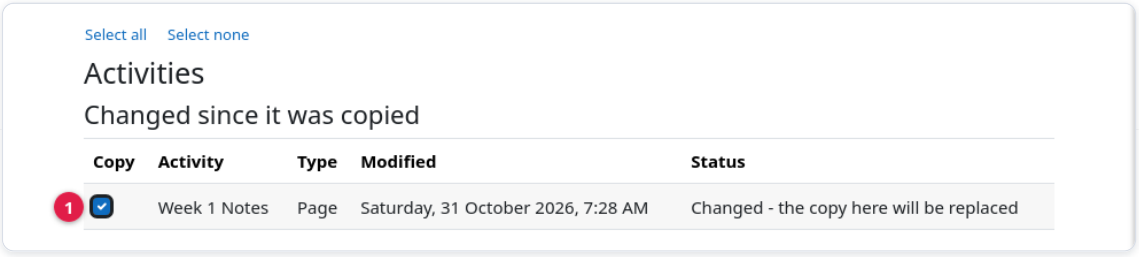
The first time you check, every new activity is ticked, ready to copy. 1 marks the tick-box of the first row. The Status column says what will happen.

4 Choose what to copy

The rows are in groups, so you can see at a glance what each tick will do:

Group	Starts	What it means
Ready to copy	ticked	Not in your course yet. A tick copies it in.
Changed since it was copied	unticked	You copied it before and it has since been edited on the other site. A tick updates your copy (see Part 3).
Already on this course	unticked	Already here. Tick only if you want a fresh copy.
Question content	unticked	Question banks, and the questions of a quiz without the quiz itself.

- **Untick** anything you do not want. **Select all** and **Select none** are at the top of the list.
- What you leave out is **not gone**: the next Check Now offers it again.



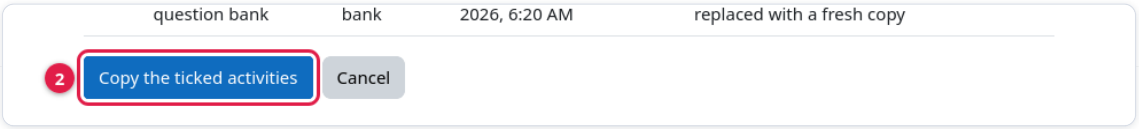
A “Changed since it was copied” row. The Status column spells out what a tick will do. 1 shows a ticked box.



"Already on this course": nothing here starts ticked, and "Select all" leaves this group alone. Tick one only to bring in a clean copy.

5 Press "Copy the ticked activities"

Scroll to the bottom and click **Copy the ticked activities** 2. Course Sync copies each ticked activity into your course, keeping it in the same section and order as on the other site. It takes a few seconds; wait for the page to finish.

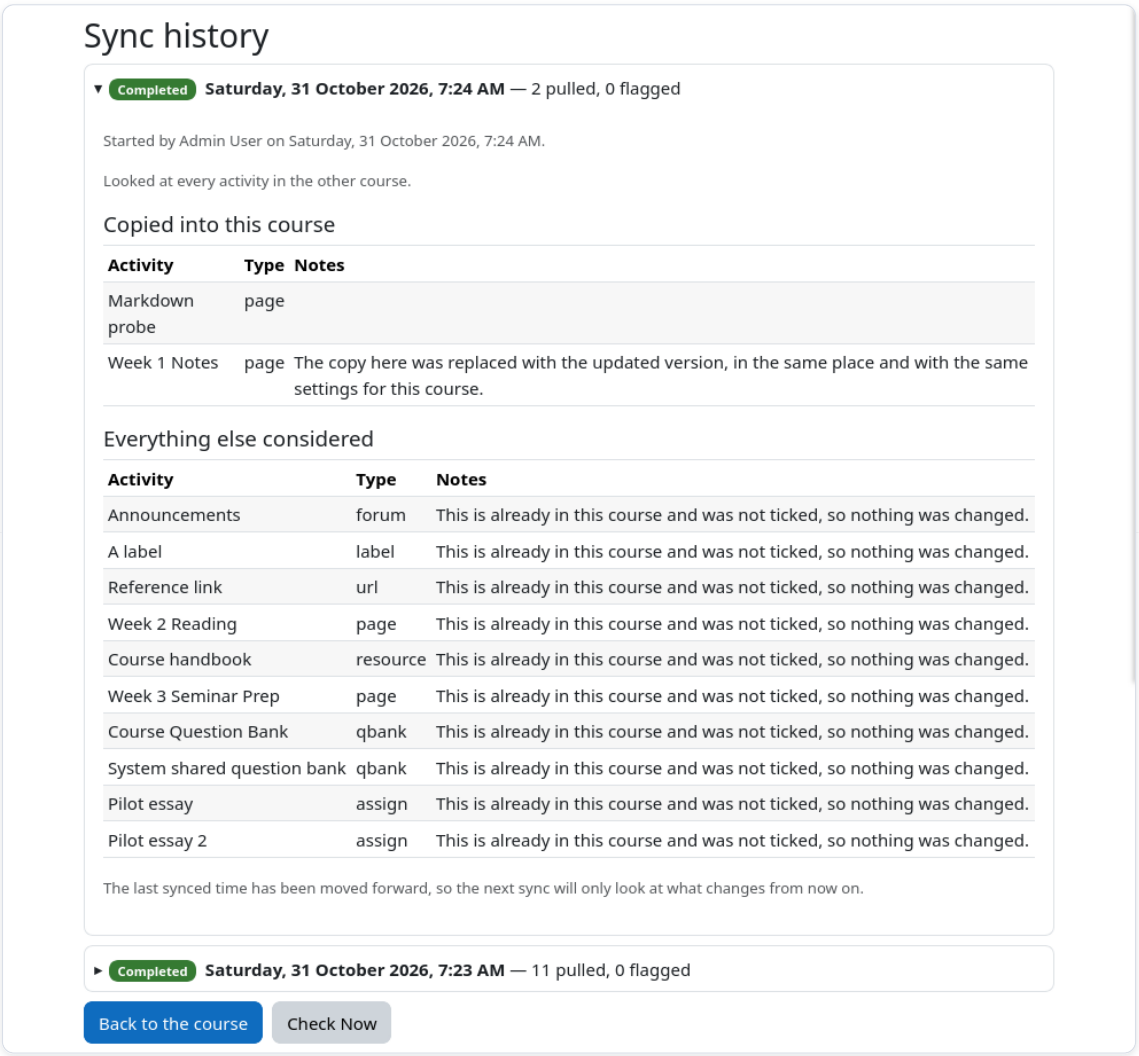


The copy button is at the bottom of the list.

6 Read the results

The sync records what happened for every activity. Open **View sync history** in the block and click the newest entry (the arrow beside it) to see:

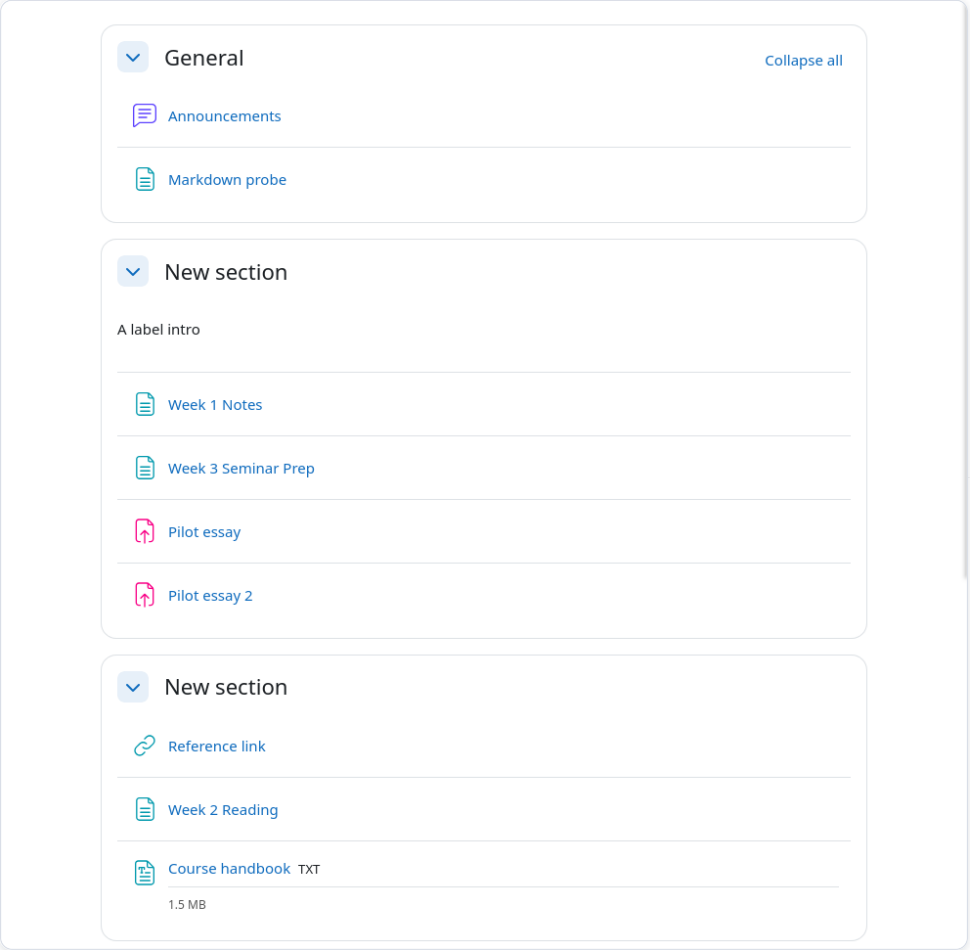
Outcome	Means
Copied	Created in your course (or your copy replaced with the updated one).
Flagged	Something was in the way, so nothing was done. The note says why. See Part 5.
Skipped	Not a type Course Sync can copy, or you chose not to copy it.
Failed	Something went wrong. It is tried again next time.



A finished sync in the history: two activities copied (one replaced with its updated version), the rest left alone because they were not ticked.

7 Look at your course

Click **Back to the course**. The copied activities are in place, in the same sections as on the other course. Open a few to check them. The copies are **set up exactly as the teacher set them up** on the other site. What students did there (posts, answers, submissions) is deliberately **not** copied.



The course after the first sync: activities arrive in their sections, ready to use.

Tip: do not change the ID number

Each copied activity carries an *ID number* that Course Sync uses to recognise it next time. If you edit it, the next sync will make a second copy.

PART 3

Keep your course up to date

When someone edits an activity on the other course, you decide whether to bring the change in. Nothing updates on its own.

8 Update a changed activity

1. Click **Check Now**. Changed activities appear under **Changed since it was copied**, **unticked**, because updating changes something already in your course.
2. Tick the ones you want to update (1).
3. Click **Copy the ticked activities**.

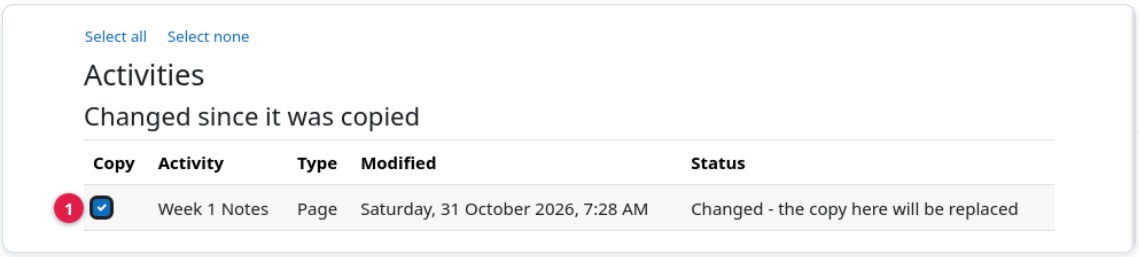
The **Status** column says which of two things will happen:

“The copy here will be replaced”

Nobody has done anything in your copy yet. The updated version takes its place: same section, position, visibility, access restrictions, completion settings and grade category. The old one goes to the recycle bin if your site has one. **Any edits you made to the copy are replaced too.**

“Will be added as a new edition”

Students already have attempts, submissions, posts or grades in your copy. **Your copy is left exactly as it is.** The update is added straight after it with **(New edition)** on the end of its name. Hide or delete the old one when you are ready.



Ticking an activity under “Changed since it was copied” (1).

9 Copy something again on purpose

Perhaps your copy was edited or broken and you want a clean one. Tick it under **Already on this course** and press the copy button. The status tells you what will happen:

Status	What a tick does
Already synced – *the copy here is replaced*	Nobody has work or grades in it, so a fresh copy takes its place.
Already synced – *a separate copy is added*	People have work in your copy. It is left alone and a fresh copy is added after it, named **"… (copy)"**.
Needs review	Something in your course already has that activity's identity, but Course Sync did not put it there. Course Sync never changes it; ticking adds a separate "(copy)".

10 Activities you already had

If your course already holds an activity with the **same type and name** as one on the other site (made by hand, imported or restored from a backup), Course Sync recognises it the first time you sync instead of offering a duplicate. Pressing the copy button *links* it to the original: from then on, later changes are offered as updates, and grades can be pulled into it. Nothing about the activity itself changes.

Two activities with the same name?
If the name is not enough to tell (two "Quiz" activities, say), Course Sync does not guess. It leaves that one under *Ready to copy*, unticked, with a note. Rename one of them to match them next time.

PART 4 · OPTIONAL

Grades, submissions and marks

Copying activities never moves anyone's personal data. If your students did the activities on the other site, with **the same usernames on both sites**, Course Sync can bring their results across too. These three buttons only appear when your administrator has switched the feature on at both sites.

Same people, same usernames

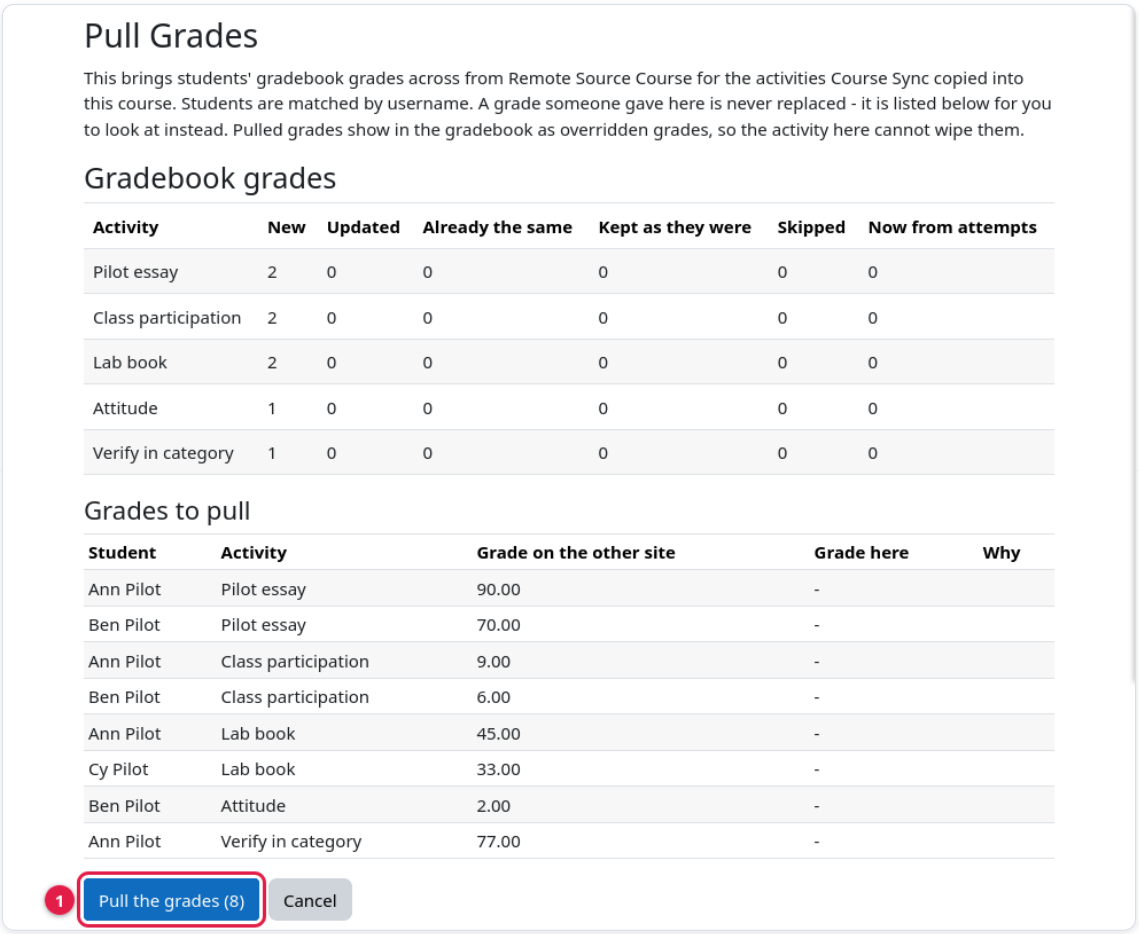
Students are matched by username only. Nobody is created or enrolled; students who are not in your course here are ignored. If a username means a different person on each site, do not use these buttons.

The pattern is always the same

Every pull page first shows what it *would* do. **Nothing is written until you press the green button at the bottom.** Whatever someone already entered here is listed as *Kept as it was* and is never replaced. You can pull again later as often as you like.

11 Pull grades

1. Click **Pull Grades** 3 in the block.
2. Read the summary table. Each row is an activity, with counts: **New** (no grade here yet), **Updated**, **Already the same**, **Kept as they were** (a different grade given here: never replaced) and **Skipped** (locked, or graded differently here).
3. Check the **Grades to pull** list. It shows each student's grade on the other site next to their grade here.
4. Click **Pull the grades** 1.



Pull Grades

This brings students' gradebook grades across from Remote Source Course for the activities Course Sync copied into this course. Students are matched by username. A grade someone gave here is never replaced - it is listed below for you to look at instead. Pulled grades show in the gradebook as overridden grades, so the activity here cannot wipe them.

Gradebook grades

Activity	New	Updated	Already the same	Kept as they were	Skipped	Now from attempts
Pilot essay	2	0	0	0	0	0
Class participation	2	0	0	0	0	0
Lab book	2	0	0	0	0	0
Attitude	1	0	0	0	0	0
Verify in category	1	0	0	0	0	0

Grades to pull

Student	Activity	Grade on the other site	Grade here	Why
Ann Pilot	Pilot essay	90.00	-	
Ben Pilot	Pilot essay	70.00	-	
Ann Pilot	Class participation	9.00	-	
Ben Pilot	Class participation	6.00	-	
Ann Pilot	Lab book	45.00	-	
Cy Pilot	Lab book	33.00	-	
Ben Pilot	Attitude	2.00	-	
Ann Pilot	Verify in category	77.00	-	

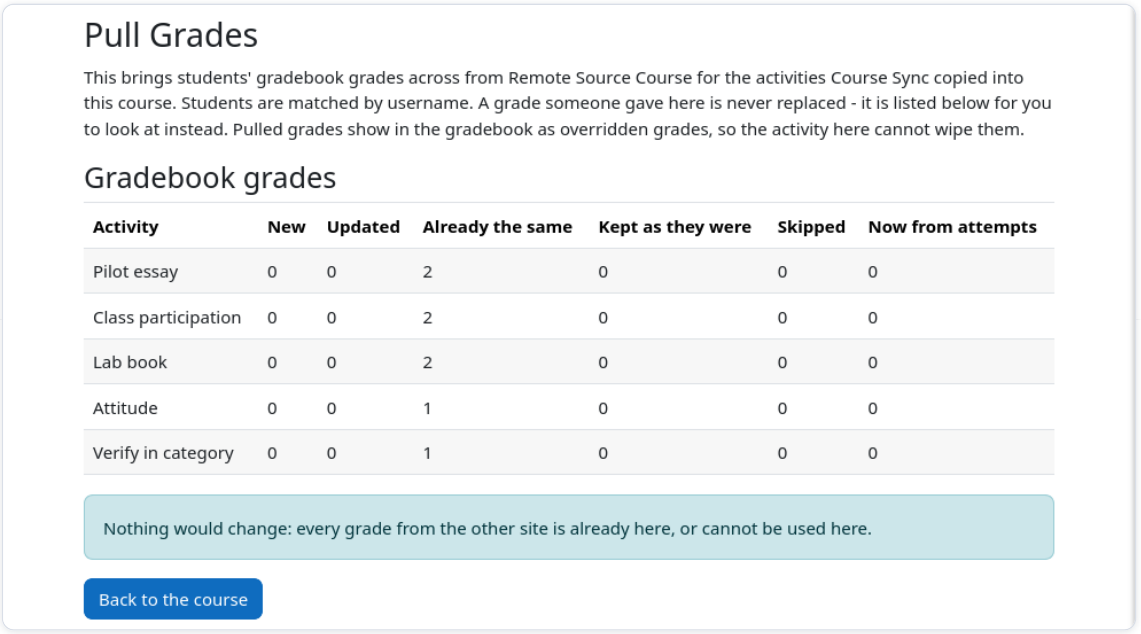
1 Pull the grades (8) Cancel

The Pull Grades preview: eight grades waiting to be pulled. A grade out of a different maximum is converted (40 out of 50 becomes 80 out of 100).

- Feedback comes across with each grade. A grade the other site hides from the student stays hidden here.
- In the gradebook, pulled grades show as **overridden** (the activity has no attempts here, and an override stops it wiping the grade). You can edit or remove a pulled grade like any other.
- **Quizzes:** finished attempts are brought in too, with times and per-question marks (not the students' actual answers). They count towards the attempt limit, and nobody is emailed.
- If your course uses separate groups and you cannot see all groups, you only see your own groups' students, as in the gradebook.

12 Pulling again

Open Pull Grades again at any time. A grade Course Sync brought across, and nobody has changed since, follows the other site: if it was regraded there, the next pull updates it. As soon as anyone here changes that grade or its feedback, it is **yours** and later pulls leave it alone. Grades removed on the other site are *not* removed here.

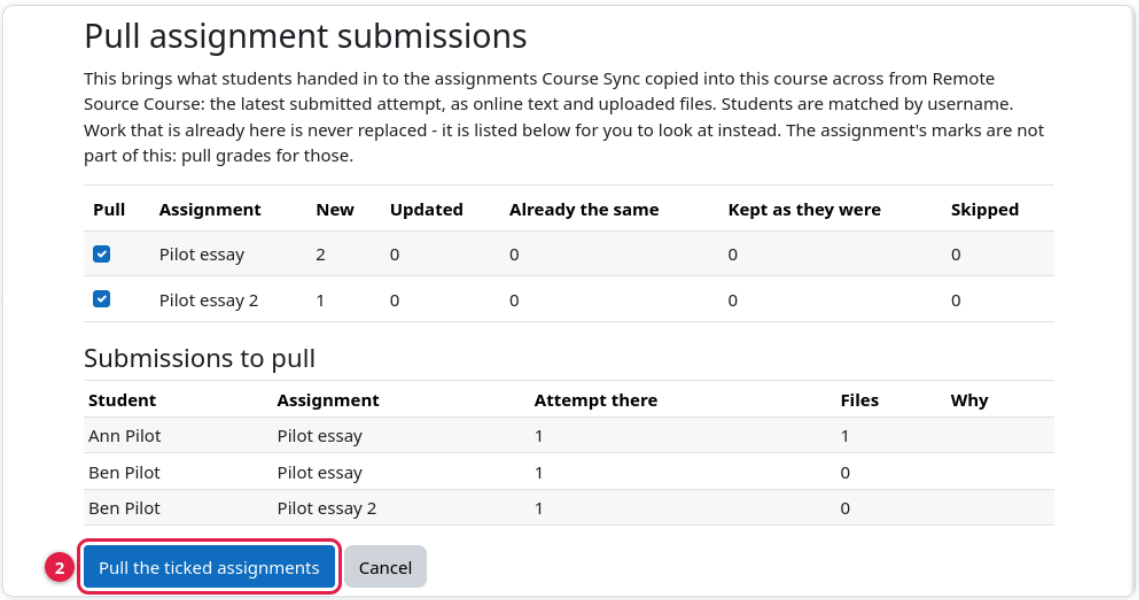


After the pull, opening the page again shows “Already the same” for every grade and “Nothing would change”.

13 Pull assignment submissions

For assignments that Course Sync copied, you can also bring across **what students handed in**: the latest handed-in attempt, as online text and uploaded files. Not drafts, not team assignments, not marks.

1. Click **Pull Submissions** in the block.
2. Each assignment has a **tick-box**, ticked where there is something to pull. Untick any you want to leave for later.
3. Check **Submissions to pull** (student, assignment, attempt number and number of files), then click **Pull the ticked assignments** 2.



Pull Submissions: three submissions in two assignments. Work already here is never replaced.

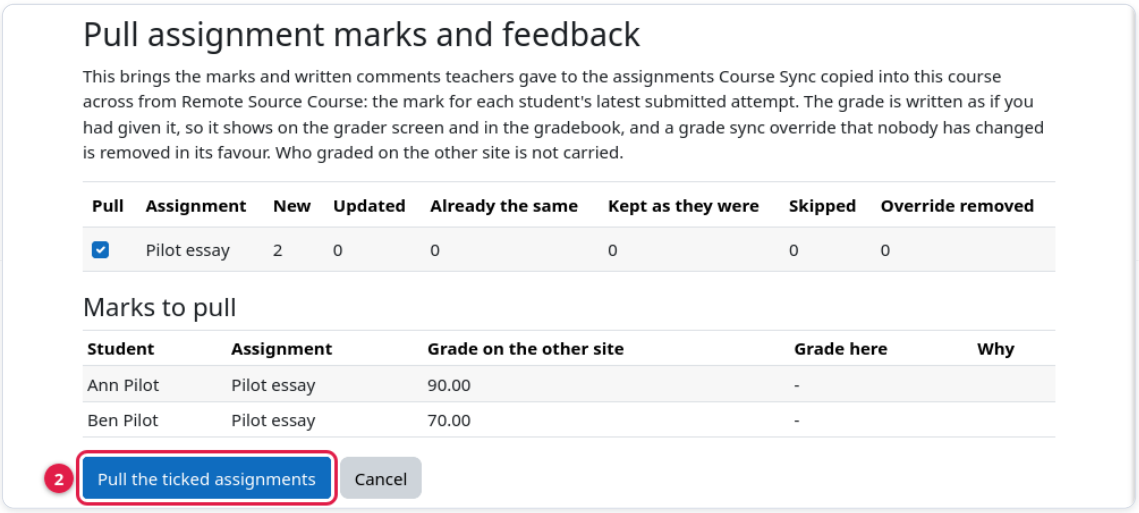
No button?

Besides the site switches, you need permission to edit other students' submissions in this course, which Moodle gives to no role by default. An administrator may have to grant it to teachers first.

14 Pull assignment marks and feedback

If teachers on the other site marked the work, bring the **mark and written comment** into the assignment here. It is written as a real assignment grade, *given by you*, so it shows on the grader screen and in the gradebook. It works without pulling the submissions first.

1. Click **Pull Marks and Feedback** in the block.
2. Untick any assignment you want to hold back (pulling marks writes grades).
3. Click **Pull the ticked assignments** 2.



Pull Marks and Feedback: two marks to pull for “Pilot essay”.

- Only assignments graded **in points** on both sites. If the totals differ, the mark is scaled (80/100 becomes 40/50).
- Scales, ungraded and team assignments are skipped. Where a marking workflow is used, only *released* marks are pulled.
- The comments feedback type must be switched on for the assignment here.
- If Pull Grades had already put an override on that student’s grade and nobody changed it, the override is removed once the real mark is in.

PART 5

History, reference and troubleshooting

15 Sync history

Click **View sync history** 4 in the block (see the picture under step 6). Every sync and grade pull is listed, newest first, with a coloured label:

- **Completed**: everything it set out to do.
- **Needs review**: something was flagged or failed.
- **Failed**: it could not run at all.

Click an entry to see who started it, what it looked at, and the full list of what was copied, flagged or skipped. Runs that did nothing are recorded too, so you can always tell whether a sync was tried. A grade pull shows only counts per activity, never which students; who got which grade is in the gradebook's own history.

What copies, and what stays behind

Course Sync copies the activity *as a teacher set it up*, not what anyone did in it.

Type	What comes across	What stays behind
Page, URL, Label, File, Folder, Book	All content, pictures and uploaded files; every book chapter in order	—
Forum, Wiki, Glossary, Choice, Feedback, Database	The activity and its settings, fields and questions	Posts, wiki pages, entries, responses and answers
Assignment	Task, dates, grading and submission types	Submissions, grades, feedback, extensions (pull them separately)
Quiz, Question bank	All settings and every standard question type, fixed or drawn at random	Attempts and statistics; questions of plugin-added types
Lesson, Workshop	Every page and path / the whole assessment form	What students did; a lesson's password
H5P, SCORM, IMS package	The package itself, checked that it opens	Attempts and tracking data
External tool, BigBlueButton, Subsection	Link and settings / room settings / the subsection and (if ticked) what is in it	The other site's keys; recordings; passwords

Anything else in the other course is listed as skipped, so you know it was seen and left. Each result says what was left behind, so you never have to find out by opening the activity.

Flagged activities

A flagged activity is one Course Sync would have copied, but something in your course already claims its place. **It never overwrites and never makes a second copy.** It stops and tells you. Once you have sorted it out (deleted the item in the way, or decided your version stands), just open **Check Now** again.

Good to know

- **Pictures and files inside text come across.** If a picture could not be brought, the results name it so you can put it back by hand.
- **A copied database has no custom CSS or JavaScript**, and **a copied lesson is not password-protected**; set a new password here if you need one. The results say when this happens.
- **A marking scale that does not exist here is dropped.** The activity arrives ungraded rather than pointing at the wrong scale.
- **Nothing is automatic.** Course Sync runs only when you choose Check Now, and results only come across when you choose a Pull button.

If you get stuck

What you see	What to do
Block says “not yet configured”	A manager has to run the setup wizard. Send them the Set-up Walk-Through.
A red message when you click Check Now (could not be reached, token not accepted, service not switched on…)	The problem is on the connection, not your course. Copy the message and send it to your administrator; it usually names the missing step.
No Pull Grades / Submissions / Marks button	The feature is off on one of the two sites, or you lack a permission (see the table at the start). Ask your administrator.
“Kept as they were” rows on a pull	Someone here already entered something different. Look at both values and decide. Course Sync will not replace them.
Something was flagged	Open the sync history entry; the note names the activity and the reason. Resolve it, then Check Now again.
A second copy appeared after a sync	The activity’s ID number was changed, or you ticked it under “Already on this course”. Delete the extra copy; do not edit ID numbers.

The short version

Open the block → **See Changes** (optional) → **Check Now** → untick what you do not want → **Copy the ticked activities** → check **View sync history**. Use the Pull buttons only if your students’ work lives on the other site.

More detail

The plugin’s `docs` folder holds `TEACHER_GUIDE.md` (the full text behind this guide), `INSTALL.md` and `SETUP_WALKTHROUGH.pdf` (for administrators).